MMSU's Commitment

Take an active role in protecting and promoting sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, responsible land use, and biodiversity conservation.

SDG 15.2.6 · Sustainable management of land for tourism (educational outreach)

Offer educational programme/outreach for local or national communities on sustainable management of land for tourism.

Evidence year: 2025 (calendar year), with continuing implementation 2024–2026

DRAFT. The 2025 evidence is MMSU's rice paddy art, a farm-tourism attraction on university demonstration fields with student guides, and the TALON farm tourism project was approved in January 2026. Neither is yet a structured training for communities. Add visitor or tour numbers and any briefing given to visitors before submitting.

Evidence from 2025

Rice Paddy Art Brings Visitors to MMSU's Farm-Tourism Demonstration Fields



Unveiling of the 2025 rice paddy art featuring CHED Chairperson Shirley C. Agrupis and her ACHIEVE agenda, MMSU Extension Demonstration Area, 22 August 2025. (Photo: MMSU STRATCOM)



Rice paddy art featuring Dingras as the Rice Granary of Ilocos Norte, MMSU Dingras Campus, unveiled 9 September 2025. (Photo: MMSU STRATCOM)

In partnership with the Department of Agriculture–Philippine Rice Research Institute (DA-PhilRice), Mariano Marcos State University held the ceremonial transplanting of its eighth annual rice paddy art on July 7, 2025, at the Extension Demonstration Area near the Twin Gate of the Batac campus, and unveiled it on August 22, 2025. The design, featuring CHED Chairperson Shirley C. Agrupis and her ACHIEVE agenda, was realized with the PalayCheck System, the

Carrageenan Plant Growth Regulator, and two rice varieties, purple rice (IR 1552) and green rice (NSIC Rc222). About 50 BS Agriculture students, with MMSU extension and research staff and PhilRice, served as guides and transplanters. MMSU President Virgilio Julius P. Manzano Jr. said the paddy art "attracts visitors, promotes research, and showcases innovation," and Extension Director Dr. Marilou Lucas described it as a statement of commitment to agri-tourism, research and rice appreciation.

On September 9, 2025, the MMSU Dingras Campus unveiled its second rice paddy art, featuring Dingras as the Rice Granary of Ilocos Norte, created by MMSU student planters with PhilRice Ilocos Norte and the Local Government Unit of Dingras. Initiated in 2024, the Dingras paddy art is aligned with Republic Act 10816, the Farm Tourism Development Act, and CAFSD Dean Dr. Charlie B. Batin commended it for boosting agro-tourism and enrolment in agriculture programmes.

Source

- MMSU News, "CHED Chairperson Agrupis to be featured in MMSU-PhilRice paddy art," 8 July 2025 https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2472/ched-chairperson-agrupis-to-be-featured-in-mmsu-philrice-paddy-art
- MMSU News, "2025 Rice Paddy art features CHED Chair Agrupis," 22 August 2025 https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2527/2025-rice-paddy-art-features-ched-chair-agrupis
- MMSU News, "Dingras campus launches rice paddy art," 12 September 2025 https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2560/dingras-campus-launches-rice-paddy-art

Continuing implementation

Policies and programmes that began before 2025 and continue to be implemented, with 2024 and 2026 activities that show the programme is ongoing. THE accepts policies that are already in place.

DOST-PCAARRD and UP-ISSI Assess MMSU's Proposed TALON Farm Tourism Project

Continuing implementation · site visit of January 15, 2026



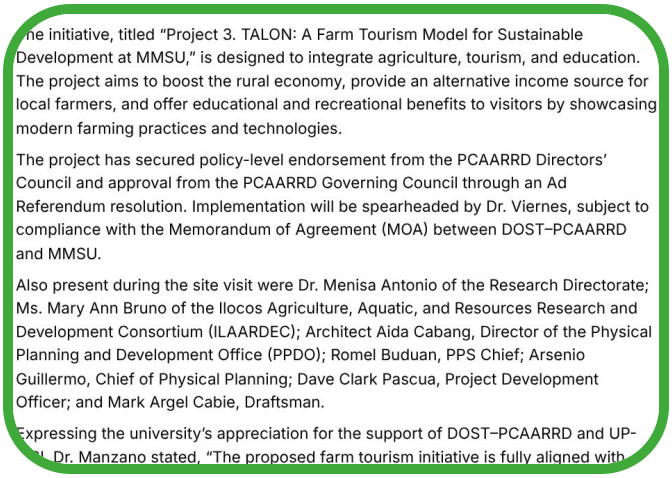
DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site

By Wimbledon Bosque

Officials from the Department of Science and Technology–Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST–PCAARRD) and the University of the Philippines–Institute for Small-Scale Industries (UP-ISSI) conducted a site visit at the Mariano Marcos State University (MMSU) Crops Research Laboratory on January 15 to assess the proposed farm tourism project under the Science for the Convergence of Agriculture and Tourism (SciCAT) Expansion Program.

The delegation, led by Assistant Professor Melanie Moraga-Leaño, Director of UP-ISSI and SciCAT Program Leader, together with UP-ISSI extension specialists Kaye Bravo-Coballes, Janelle Faye Tanudtanud, Joshua Garcia, and Garry Nipales, along with Dianne Cabello of the Technology Transfer and Promotion Division, DOST–PCAARRD, [illegible] welcomed by MMSU President Virgilio Julius Manzano, Jr.

Capture: MMSU News, 20 January 2026, "DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site" (headline and opening paragraphs).



[illegible]he initiative, titled "Project 3. TALON: A Farm Tourism Model for Sustainable Development at MMSU," is designed to integrate agriculture, tourism, and education. The project aims to boost the rural economy, provide an alternative income source for local farmers, and offer educational and recreational benefits to visitors by showcasing modern farming practices and technologies.

The project has secured policy-level endorsement from the PCAARRD Directors' Council and approval from the PCAARRD Governing Council through an Ad Referendum resolution. Implementation will be spearheaded by Dr. Viernes, subject to compliance with the Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) between DOST–PCAARRD and MMSU.

Also present during the site visit were Dr. Menisa Antonio of the Research Directorate; Ms. Mary Ann Bruno of the Ilocos Agriculture, Aquatic, and Resources Research and Development Consortium (ILAARDEC); Architect Aida Cabang, Director of the Physical Planning and Development Office (PPDO); Romel Buduan, PPS Chief; Arsenio Guillermo, Chief of Physical Planning; Dave Clark Pascua, Project Development Officer; and Mark Argel Cabie, Draftsman.

Expressing the university's appreciation for the support of DOST–PCAARRD and UP-[illegible], Dr. Manzano stated, "The proposed farm tourism initiative is fully aligned with

Capture: the same article, on Project 3 TALON and the approval of the PCAARRD Governing Council.

On January 15, 2026, officials of the Department of Science and Technology–Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST-PCAARRD) and the University of the Philippines–Institute for Small-Scale Industries (UP-ISSI) visited the MMSU Crops Research Laboratory to assess a proposed farm tourism project under the Science for the Convergence of Agriculture and Tourism (SciCAT) Expansion Program. The delegation, led by UP-ISSI Director and SciCAT Program Leader Asst. Prof. Melanie Moraga-Leaño, was welcomed by MMSU President Virgilio Julius P. Manzano Jr. and guided through an on-site technical walkthrough by MMSU's Vice President for Research, Development and Innovation, the Director for Research, Innovation and Technology, the dean of the College of Business, Economics and Accountancy, and project members from its Department of Tourism and Hospitality Management led by Dr. Eva Jean Viernes. Planners of the Physical Planning and Development Office and the Ilocos Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development Consortium (ILAARRDEC) also took part.

The project, "Project 3. TALON: A Farm Tourism Model for Sustainable Development at MMSU," is designed to integrate agriculture, tourism and education. It aims to boost the rural economy, provide an alternative income source for local farmers, and offer educational and recreational benefits to visitors by showcasing modern farming practices and technologies. The project has the endorsement of the PCAARRD Directors' Council and the approval of the PCAARRD Governing Council through an Ad Referendum resolution, and its implementation, led by Dr. Viernes, is subject to the memorandum of agreement between DOST-PCAARRD and MMSU. MMSU is among

the select institutions developing science-and-technology-based agri-tourism hubs under SciCAT, which turns farms into tourism sites to promote innovation, entrepreneurship and community development.

Source

- MMSU News, “DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site,” 20 January 2026
  https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2869/dost-pcaarrd-up-issi-visit-proposed-mmsu-farm-tourism-project-site

Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park Is Enriched with 28 Native Tree Species

Continuing implementation · since 2023

On January 13, 2023, MMSU planted 120 more seedlings of 28 native tree species and two bamboo species at the Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park on the Main Campus, led by then President Shirley C. Agrupis with administrators, faculty, staff and students. The park is used as a field laboratory for classes and was identified for development into a health and wellness tourism hub, a plan endorsed by the provincial government and aligned with the Health and Wellness Complex of the College of Medicine.

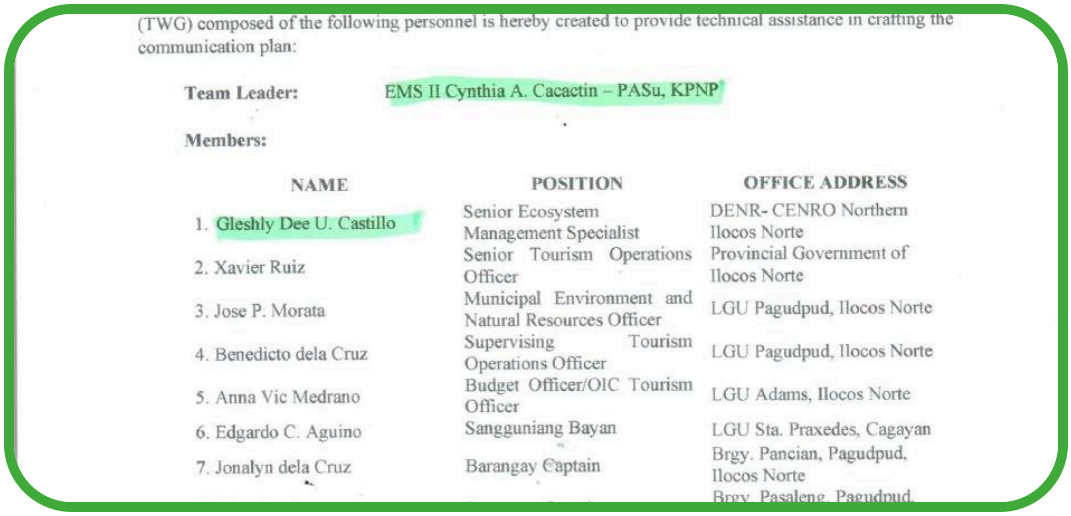
The planting continues a tradition that began in 2017 with the Green Wall project on the Batac campus and extends to the Nagbacsan site and the Currimao, Dingras and Laoag campuses, as the university’s contribution to the provincial “Green Wall of Ilocos Norte” and the National Greening Program of the Department of Environment and Natural Resources.

Source

- MMSU News, “More trees planted at MMSU to establish ‘health tourism’ hub,” 13 January 2023
  https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/news/more-trees-planted-at-mmsu-to-establish-health-tourism-hub

MMSU Expert Serves on the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park Technical Working Group

Continuing role · appointment of 29 March 2023



(TWG) composed of the following personnel is hereby created to provide technical assistance in crafting the communication plan:

Team Leader: EMS II Cynthia A. Cacactin – PASu, KPNP

Members:

NAME	POSITION	OFFICE ADDRESS
1. Gleshly Dee U. Castillo	Senior Ecosystem Management Specialist	DENR- CENRO Northern Ilocos Norte
2. Xavier Ruiz	Senior Tourism Operations Officer	Provincial Government of Ilocos Norte
3. Jose P. Morata	Municipal Environment and Natural Resources Officer	LGU Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
4. Benedicto dela Cruz	Supervising Tourism Operations Officer	LGU Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
5. Anna Vic Medrano	Budget Officer/OIC Tourism Officer	LGU Adams, Ilocos Norte
6. Edgardo C. Aguino	Sangguniang Bayan	LGU Sta. Praxedes, Cagayan
7. Jonalyn dela Cruz	Barangay Captain	Brgy. Pancian, Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
		Brgy. Pasaleng, Pagudpud,

Document: DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024 (29 March 2023) naming Dr. Arlene L. Gonzales of MMSU to the KPNP Technical Working Group.

Through DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024, dated March 29, 2023, Dr. Arlene L. Gonzales of MMSU was named a member of the Technical Working Group that prepares the Communication Plan of the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park (KPNP), a protected area in Ilocos Norte. The group, led by the KPNP Protected Area Superintendent, brings together DENR offices, the Provincial Government of Ilocos Norte, the LGUs of Pagudpud and Adams in Ilocos Norte and Sta. Praxedes in Cagayan, barangay officials and Northwestern University.

The Communication Plan supports the goal of the KPNP Protected Area Management Plan to adopt and carry out effective information and education campaigns for biological diversity conservation and for the promotion of the protected area as a major ecotourism destination.

Source

- DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024, 29 March 2023 (MMSU SDG 15 page) https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/resources/1TCpM-DxbkgfOh4QGwlfVr8QavCchKWKu/data